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Act East: Balancing China in the Indo–Pacific

Background: China's Rise and the Indo–Pacific

In 1949, decades of civil war in China came to an end with the victory of Communist forces under Mao Zedong and the establishment of the People's Republic of China (PRC). The previous Chinese government of the Kuomintang (KMT) fled to the island of Formosa, today's Taiwan, where it continued to claim legitimate rule over the entire country as the Republic of China. By 1950, the PRC had not just annexed Tibet, but it went to war with the United States and United Nations in Korea and established a strong partnership with the Soviet Union that extended to nuclear, scientific, economic and military cooperation. But by the 1960s, fissures began to emerge between Beijing and Moscow, leading eventually to a sharp border conflict between the two nuclear-armed communist countries in 1969. In the United States, President Richard Nixon and his National Security Advisor Henry Kissinger sought to take advantage of the Sino–Soviet split. This was engineered during a secret visit to China by Kissinger (via Pakistan), and subsequently in an historic visit by Nixon to China. As part of this thaw, the United States recognized the PRC as a member of the United Nations (including as a permanent member of the Security Council), at the expense of Taiwan and established full diplomatic relations with Beijing a few years later. [1]

Throughout the 1970s and 1980s, the United States and China developed an increasingly close partnership, often directed against their common adversary, the Soviet Union. In the late 1970s, China underwent a messy